

Final Project Reflection

This was one of the hardest assignments for me, in my opinion, but also one of the ones that taught me the most. At first, it felt easy enough because the smaller classes made sense to me. Classes like Exit, Player, Item, Location, and even Inventory felt straightforward because each one had a clear purpose. It actually felt like I was coding a real game, and that part was exciting. I understood that one class stores items, one stores rooms, one stores the player state, and so on. The real problem started when I had to connect everything together. That was where I got stuck. The hardest part by far was the main WonderlandGame.java class. That file was painful for me because it controls the whole game loop, the room changes, the item interactions, the file loading, and the command handling. I got very confused about where to start and how all the methods were supposed to work together. I especially struggled with ArrayList, arrays, and loading data from the text files. I could understand the idea of the files, but turning each line into objects and then using those objects in the program was difficult for me. I was stuck for days and felt like I was just guessing. At one point, I honestly felt like I needed to restart and go back to basics. Instead of trying to force the code, I realized I needed a better plan. I watched the movie again because I had forgotten a lot of the details of the story, and that helped me understand the characters, rooms, and objects better. After that, the biggest improvement I made was creating a kind of mind map or storyboard on my iPad. I drew each room, how the rooms connect, which directions lead where, what items are in each room, and what role each room plays in the game. That helped a lot because I could finally visualize the program before trying to code it. Once I had that layout, it became easier to design the game world and make decisions about the logic. I first built a very short and rough version of the game and then asked my friend to test it. He hated it at first, which honestly helped me a lot because I realized the game was not clear at all. He was confused about the goal, where to start, what commands to use, and what the point of the game even was. That showed me that just because I understood the code did not mean a player would understand the game. Because of that, I added more hints, clearer room descriptions, better instructions, and a help system. I also made sure the game explained the goal, the safe room, movement commands, and shortcuts like "n" for north. I wanted the user experience to make more sense. Another important design change was adding both a win condition and a lose condition. At one point, the game only had a win state, which made it feel incomplete. I later added a lose condition in the

Queen's Garden, where using the flamingo like a croquet mallet causes the queen to react, and the player loses. That made the game feel more like a proper text adventure. I also learned a lot about debugging, testing, and refining logic with if statements, loops, methods, object-oriented design, and file handling. Overall, this assignment was frustrating most of the time but worth it at the end.